

OCR Level 3 Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Sociology

Version 1: First assessment 2016

This draft qualification has not yet been accredited by Ofqual. It is published to enable teachers to have early sight of our proposed approach to Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Sociology. Further changes may be required and no assurance can be given at this time that the proposed qualification will be made available in its current form, or that it will be accredited in time for first teaching in 2015 and first award in 2016.

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1 Why choose an OCR AS Level in Sociology?

1a. Why choose an OCR qualification?

Choose OCR and you've got the reassurance that you're working with one of the UK's leading exam boards. Our new AS Level in Sociology course has been developed in consultation with teachers, employers and Higher Education to provide students with a qualification that's relevant to them and meets their needs.

We're part of the Cambridge Assessment Group, Europe's largest assessment agency and a department of the University of Cambridge. Cambridge Assessment plays a leading role in developing and delivering assessments throughout the world, operating in over 150 countries.

We work with a range of education providers, including schools, colleges, workplaces and other institutions in both the public and private sectors. Over 13,000 centres choose our A Levels, GCSEs and vocational qualifications including Cambridge Nationals, Cambridge Technicals and Cambridge Progression.

Our Specifications

We believe in developing specifications that help you bring the subject to life and inspire your students to achieve more.

We've created teacher-friendly specifications based on extensive research and engagement with the teaching community. They're designed to be straightforward and accessible so that you can tailor the delivery

of the course to suit your needs. We aim to encourage learners to become responsible for their own learning, confident in discussing ideas, innovative and engaged.

We provide a range of support services designed to help you at every stage, from preparation through to the delivery of our specifications. This includes:

- A wide range of high-quality creative resources including:
 - o Delivery Guides
 - o Transition Guides
 - o Topic Exploration Packs
 - o Lesson Elements
 - o ...and much more.
- Access to subject specialists to support you through the transition and throughout the lifetimes of the specifications.
- CPD/Training for teachers including face-to-face events to introduce the qualifications and prepare you for first teaching.
- Active Results – our free results analysis service to help you review the performance of individual students or whole schools.
- ExamCreator – our new online past papers service that enables you to build your own test papers from past OCR exam questions.

All AS level qualifications offered by OCR are accredited by Ofqual, the Regulator for qualifications offered in England.

1b. Why choose an OCR AS Level in Sociology?

This practical and engaging course has been redeveloped after feedback from teachers and other key stakeholders. The content has been designed to inspire, nurture and develop learners. The most popular aspects of previous qualifications have been retained or enhanced. This qualification is designed to foster the development of critical and reflective thinking with a respect for social diversity; and to encourage an awareness of the importance of social structure and social action in explaining social issues.

Learners are encouraged to develop their own sociological awareness through active involvement with the contemporary social world.

Our AS Level in Sociology specification is designed to encourage learners to be inspired, moved and changed by following a broad, coherent, satisfying and worthwhile course of study and to reflect on their own experience of the social world to enhance their ability to play informed roles within different social contexts. It prepares learners to make informed decisions about further learning opportunities and career choices.

Aims and learning outcomes

The main purpose of the specification is to prepare learners to progress to a qualification in the same subject area but at a higher level of or requiring more specific knowledge, skills and understanding.

Secondary purposes include preparing learners to progress to a qualification in another subject area, preparing learners for employment and giving learners personal growth and engagement in learning.

Our AS level specification in Sociology enables learners to:

- recognise that their sociological knowledge, understanding and skills help them to develop an understanding of the interrelationships between individuals, groups, institutions and societies
- analyse critically the nature and sources of information and to base reasoned judgements and arguments on evidence
- organise and communicate their knowledge and understanding in different and creative ways, and reach substantiated judgements
- appreciate the significance of theoretical and conceptual issues in sociological debate
- understand and evaluate sociological methodology and a range of research methods through active involvement in the research process
- develop skills that enable individuals to focus on their personal identity, roles and responsibilities within society
- develop a lifelong interest in social issues.

1c. What are the key features of this specification?

From September 2015, the AS Level in Sociology is made up of **two** mandatory components which are externally assessed.

Our AS Level in Sociology qualification has been designed to be co-teachable with the first year of the A level. The specification content is identical to the A level content for Component 1 and Component 2 Section A. Component 2 Section B has a reduced amount of content.

Here are some of the key benefits of our new AS Level in Sociology specification for you and your students:

- a straightforward specification with detailed guidance to support delivery
- improved support, resources and more teacher guidance
- strong focus on key sociological themes
- choice for teachers and students with options in Component 1.

1d. How do I find out more information?

If already using OCR specifications you can contact us at: www.ocr.org.uk

If not already registered you can find out more information on the benefits of becoming one at: www.ocr.org.uk

If you are not yet an approved centre and would like to become one go to:
www.ocr.org.uk

Find out more?

Ask the Subject Specialist

Email: sociology@ocr.org.uk

Telephone: 01223 553998

Join our Sociology community:
www.ocr.org.uk

2 The specification overview

2a. Overview of AS Level in Sociology (H180)

Learners must complete both components (01-02).

Content Overview	Assessment Overview	
Introducing socialisation, culture and identity Themes developed through the context of one of three options: - Families and relationships - Youth subcultures - Media	Socialisation, culture and identity (01) 75 Marks 1 hour 30 minutes written paper	50% of total AS level
Research methods and researching social inequalities Understanding social inequalities	Researching and understanding social inequalities (02)* 75 Marks 1 hour 30 minutes written paper	50% of total AS level

*Indicates synoptic assessment.

2b. Content of AS Level in Sociology (H180)

The AS level specification content is set out in **three** parts:

1. **Key questions** – the key question to be explored.
2. **Content** – sociological concepts and theories which should be included for each key issue.

3. **Learners should** – this provides content amplification to explain in more detail what learners need to know for the assessment of this qualification.

Although not directly assessed, learners are encouraged to carry out their own small-scale research projects as a way of enhancing their sociological understanding of methodology, substantive topic areas and core themes.

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2c. Content of Socialisation, culture and identity: (01)

This component introduces learners to the key themes of socialisation, culture and identity and develops these themes through the context of one of three options of Families and relationships, Youth subcultures or Media.

These options develop skills that enable individuals to focus on their personal identity, roles and responsibilities within society and develop a lifelong interest in social issues. The following tables outline the content that must be studied. This is split into two sections, Section A and Section B.

Section A: Introducing socialisation, culture and identity		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
1. What is culture?	Culture, norms and values Types of culture: • subculture • high culture • popular culture • global culture • consumer culture Cultural diversity Cultural hybridity	be able to understand the relative nature of culture, norms and values. Cross-cultural material should be used here.
2. What is socialisation?	Primary and secondary socialisation Agencies of socialisation: • family • peer group • media • religion • education • workplace Nature/nurture debate	be able to link definitions of primary socialisation and secondary socialisation to relevant agencies of socialisation, understanding that socialisation is a lifelong process. understand the link between socialisation and the creation of identities consider the implications of the nature/nurture debate for an understanding of socialisation.

Section A: Introducing socialisation, culture and identity		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
<i>cont.</i> What is socialisation?	Formal agencies of social control: • police • law/legal system • courts • government • military Informal agencies of social control: • family • peer group/ subcultures • media • religion • education • workplace	explore the overlap between formal and informal social control for work, education and religion.
3. What is identity?	The concept of identity Aspects of identity and the associated cultural characteristics: • ethnicity • nationality • gender • social class • sexuality • age • disability Hybrid identities	understand how identities are created including the influence of agencies of socialisation. understand the different aspects of an individual's identity, their relative importance to individuals and ways in which they may intersect. Learners should consider changing identities.

Section B Option 1: Families and relationships		
This option focuses on the family as a central agency of socialisation and a main transmitter of culture in contemporary society. It allows learners to explore contemporary family structures and relationships.		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
1. How diverse are modern families?	The diversity of family and household types in the contemporary UK: • nuclear families • extended families • lone parent families • reconstituted families • same-sex families • non-family households Aspects of and reasons for family and household diversity in the contemporary UK, including: • trends in marriage, divorce and cohabitation • demographic changes: - o birth-rate - o family size - o age at marriage - o age of child-bearing - o ageing population • family diversity in terms of: - o social class - o ethnicity - o sexuality The ideology of the nuclear family and the theoretical debates about the role and desirability of the nuclear family in contemporary society: • functionalism • New Right • Marxism • feminism • postmodernism Debates about the extent of family diversity in the contemporary UK	also consider newer/emerging types of families and households. have an overview of trends over the last 30 years and consider the key reasons for these changes. Detailed knowledge of statistics on marriage, divorce and demographic changes is not required. consider issues of consensus versus conflict, social order and control in relation to theoretical views of the role of the family in contemporary society. A theoretical approach to considering the extent of family diversity should be taken.

Section B Option 1: Families and relationships		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
2. To what extent are roles and relationships within families and households changing?	Roles and relationships between partners and how they are changing, including issues of power	consider a range of issues including the domestic division of labour and the 'dark side' of the family. A theoretical approach should be taken, applying functionalist, Marxist and feminist approaches.
	Roles and relationships between parents and children and how they are changing, including issues of power	consider issues such as the growth of the child-centred family and the extension of childhood. Learners should consider the impact of the ageing population on the relationship between grandparents, parents and children. A theoretical approach should be taken, applying feminist approaches.

Section B Option 2: Youth subcultures		
This option focuses on youth as an important period in the socialisation process when individuals are developing a sense of identity within their peer groups. It allows learners to explore different types of youth subcultures and the roles they may play in society.		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
1. How and why are youth culture and subcultures formed?	Theoretical views of the role and formation of youth culture and subcultures: • functionalism • Marxism/neo-Marxism • feminism • postmodernism	use illustrative examples of subcultures to explore how and why youth culture and subcultures are formed.
	Subcultures as related to: • social class • gender • ethnicity • hybridity	consider issues of consensus versus conflict, social order and control in relation to theoretical views of the role and formation of youth culture and subculture.
2. Why do young people participate in deviant subcultures?	Deviant subcultures: • delinquent subcultures • criminal subcultures • spectacular youth subcultures • anti-school subcultures • gangs	consider newer/emerging types of deviant subcultures.
	Patterns and trends in youth deviance related to: • social class • gender • ethnicity	consider patterns and trends (within the last 30 years) of youth deviance based on the evidence presented by official statistics.

Section B Option 2: Youth subcultures		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
<i>cont.</i> Why do young people participate in deviant subcultures?	Explanations for young people participating in deviant subcultures: • functionalism / New Right • Marxism / neo-Marxism • interactionism • culture and identity The media and youth deviance: • deviance amplification • folk devils • moral panics	consider both theoretical and identity based explanations, which could include issues of ethnic identity and gender.

Section B Option 3: Media		
This option focuses on how media plays an increasingly important role as an agent of socialisation in contemporary society. It allows learners to explore a range of evidence relating to media representations and media effects.		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
1. How are different social groups represented in the media?	Evidence of representations in the media and how far these are changing in relation to: • ethnicity (majority and minority ethnic groups) • gender (masculinity and femininity) • social class (middle, working, upper, under) • age (young and old) Theoretical views of media representations: • Marxism • neo-Marxism • pluralism • feminism • postmodernism	be able to discuss representation of a range of ethnicities. For example learners could consider UK nationalities (Irish, Scottish, Welsh, English) and also newer immigrant groups as well as more established minority ethnic groups. understand explanations for these representations, and any changing representations, utilising theoretical perspectives as appropriate. consider issues of consensus versus conflict, social order and control in relation to theoretical views of media representations. use postmodernism as a critique of other theoretical views.
2. What effect do the media have on audiences?	Theoretical views of media effects: • direct • indirect • active audience The role of the media in deviance amplification and the creation of moral panics	understand a range of theories on the effects of the media on the audience, including: hypodermic syringe; two-step flow; cultural effects; uses and gratifications.

2c. Content of Researching and understanding social inequalities:
(02)

This component explores the methods of sociological enquiry and develops knowledge and understanding of contemporary social processes and social change in the context of social inequality and difference. This component aims to foster the development of critical and reflective thinking with a respect for social diversity in terms of social class, gender, ethnicity and age. It develops links between the nature of sociological thought and methods of sociological enquiry.

Although not directly assessed, this component encourages learners to carry out their own small-scale research projects as a way of enhancing their sociological understanding of methodology, substantive topic areas and core themes.

The following tables outline the content that must be studied. This is split into two sections. Section A and Section B.

[illegible]

Section A: Research methods and researching social inequalities		
Key questions	Content	Learners should:
2. What are the main stages of the research process?	Key concepts in the research process: • factors influencing the choice of research topic • aims/hypothesis/research questions • primary data • secondary data • operationalisation • pilot studies • data collection • respondent validation • longitudinal studies • interpretation of data • the relationship between sociology and social policy	consider how sociological research contributes to social policy.
	Sampling process	understand the practical, ethical and theoretical factors influencing choice of sampling process.
	Sampling techniques • random • systematic • stratified • snowball • volunteer • opportunity • purposive • quota	understand the advantages and disadvantages of random and non-random sampling techniques.
	Access and gatekeeping	understand how samples are accessed and the issues with access.
	Ethics	understand ethical considerations such as those used by the British Sociological Association and why ethical principles should be followed.

Section A: Research methods and researching social inequalities		
Key questions	Content	Learners should
3. Which methods are used in sociological research?	Research methods: • questionnaires • structured interviews • statistical data (official and non-official) • content analysis • observations (participant/non-participant/covert/overt) • unstructured interviews • semi structured interviews • ethnography Quantitative and qualitative data Mixed methods • triangulation • methodological pluralism	consider the uses of research methods in the context of social inequalities.

Section B: Understanding social inequalities		
Within this section learners will have the opportunity to develop knowledge and understanding of contemporary patterns and trends of social inequality.		
Key questions	Content	Learners should
1. What are the main patterns and trends in social inequality and difference?	Social inequality and difference in relation to: • social class • gender	consider the main patterns and trends in relation to work and employment, income and wealth, poverty, and social mobility. Patterns and trends in the UK may be compared to general global patterns and trends. consider evidence of social inequalities from a range of areas of social life. consider how social inequalities affect life chances.
2. How can patterns and trends in social inequality and difference be explained?	The main sociological explanations of social inequality and difference: • functionalism • Marxism • feminism	have an understanding of the distinctive concepts and ideas associated with each theory.

2d. Prior learning, knowledge and progression

No prior knowledge of the subject is required. The specification builds on, but does not depend on, the knowledge, understanding and skills specified for GCSE Sociology. It is recommended that learners have attained communication and literacy skills at a level equivalent to GCSE Grade C in English.

Throughout the course of study, learners are encouraged to develop a critical awareness of sociological concepts and issues in contemporary society. This specification is designed to foster the development of critical and reflective thinking with a respect for social diversity; and to encourage an

awareness of the importance of social structure and social action in explaining social issues.

The specification therefore provides a suitable foundation for the study of sociology or related courses at a higher level.

Equally it is suitable for preparing learners intending to progress to a qualification in another subject area, preparing learners for employment and giving learners personal growth and engagement in learning.

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3 Assessment of OCR AS in Sociology

3a. Forms of assessment

The AS Level in Sociology is a linear qualification with 100% external assessment.

This qualification consists of **two** examined components. Both Sections A and B of each component will test all three Assessment Objectives.

Component 01:

Socialisation, culture and identity

Section A: Introducing socialisation, culture and identity

A mix of short and medium tariff compulsory questions, some based on source material.

Section B: Options

Learners choose **one** from a choice of three options (either Families and relationships, Youth subcultures or Media)

Within each option, there will be three questions that will test the quality of extended responses via the levels of response mark scheme.

Component 02:

Researching and understanding social inequalities

Section A: Research methods and researching social inequalities

A mix of short and medium tariff compulsory questions, some based on source material.

Section B: Understanding social inequalities

There will be two compulsory questions that will test the quality of extended responses via the levels of response mark scheme.

3b. Assessment availability

There will be one examination series available each year in June to **all** learners.

This specification will be certificated from the June 2016 examination series onwards.

3c. Assessment objectives (AO)

There are three assessment objectives in OCR AS level Sociology.

These are detailed in the table below:

	Assessment Objective	Weighting
AO1	Demonstrate knowledge and understanding of: - sociological theories, concepts and evidence - sociological research methods	40-50%
AO2	Apply sociological theories, concepts, evidence and research methods to a range of issues	30-35%
AO3	Analyse and evaluate sociological theories, concepts, evidence and research methods in order to: - present arguments - make judgements - draw conclusions	20-25%

The assessment objective weightings for each component are detailed in the table below:

Component	% of AS Level		
	AO1	AO2	AO3
Socialisation, culture and identity (H180/01)	45 – 50%	30 – 35%	15 – 20%
Researching and understanding social inequalities (H180/02)	45 – 50%	25 – 30%	20 – 25%

3d. Written communication skills: assessment of extended responses

The assessment materials for this qualification provide learners with the opportunity to demonstrate their ability to construct and develop a sustained line of

reasoning which is coherent, relevant, substantiated and logically structured. The marks for extended responses are integrated into the marking criteria.

3e. Synoptic assessment

Synoptic assessment draws together the knowledge, understanding and skills learnt in different aspects of the AS level Sociology course. It includes the explicit assessment of understanding of the connections between the nature of sociological thought; methods of sociological enquiry; and the two core themes using higher order skills.

Synoptic learning in sociology engages students in theoretical debate while encouraging an active involvement in the research process. It fosters a critical awareness of contemporary social processes and change.

Learners are encouraged to think holistically and develop their skills of thinking as a sociologist.

3f. Calculating Qualification Results

A learner's overall qualification grade for AS level in Sociology will be calculated by adding together their marks from the two components taken to give their total weighted mark.

This mark will then be compared to the qualification level grade boundaries for the qualification for the relevant exam series to determine the learner's overall qualification grade.

4 Admin: what you need to know

The information in this section is designed to give an overview of the processes involved in administering this qualification so that you can speak to your exams officer. All of the following processes require you to submit something to OCR by a specific deadline.

More information about these processes, together with the deadlines, can be found in the *OCR Admin Guide and Entry Codes: 14–19 Qualifications*, which can be downloaded from the OCR website: www.ocr.org.uk

4a. Pre-assessment

Estimated entries

Estimated entries are your best projection of the number of learners who will be entered for a qualification in a particular series.

Estimated entries should be submitted to OCR by the specified deadline. They are free and do not commit your centre in any way.

Final entries

Final entries provide OCR with detailed data for each learner, showing each assessment to be taken. It is essential that you use the correct entry code, considering the relevant entry rules.

Final entries must be submitted to OCR by the published deadlines or late entry fees will apply.

All learners taking AS level in Sociology must be entered using the entry code H180.

Entry code	Title	Component code	Component title	Assessment type
H180	AS Sociology	01	Socialisation, culture and identity	External Assessment
		02	Researching and understanding social inequalities	External Assessment

Estimated grades

An estimated grade is the grade the centre expects a learner to achieve for a

qualification. These should be submitted to OCR by the specified deadline.

4b. Accessibility and special consideration

The AS level qualification and subject criteria have been reviewed in order to identify any feature which could disadvantage candidates who share a protected characteristic as defined by the Equality Act 2010. All reasonable steps have been taken to minimise any such disadvantage.

Reasonable adjustments and access arrangements allow learners with special educational needs, disabilities or temporary injuries to access the assessment and show what they know and can do, without changing the demands of the assessment. Applications for these should be made before the

examination series. Detailed information about eligibility for access arrangements can be found in the *JCQ Access Arrangements and Reasonable Adjustments*.

Special consideration is a post-assessment adjustment to marks or grades to reflect temporary injury, illness or other indisposition at the time the assessment was taken.

Detailed information about eligibility for special consideration can be found in the *JCQ A guide to the special consideration process*.

4c. External assessment arrangements

Regulations governing examination arrangements are contained in the *JCQ Instructions for conducting examinations*.

4d. Results and certificates

Grade scale

Advanced Subsidiary qualifications are graded on the scale: A, B, C, D, E, where A is the highest. Learners who fail to reach the

minimum standard for E will be Unclassified (U). Only subjects in which grades A to E are attained will be recorded on certificates

Results

Results are released to centres and learners for information and to allow any queries to be resolved **before** certificates are issued.

Centres will have access to the following results' information for each learner:

- the grade for the qualification
- the raw mark for each component
- the total weighted mark for the qualification.

The following supporting information will be available:

- raw mark grade boundaries for each component
- weighted mark grade boundaries for each qualification.

Until certificates are issued, results are deemed to be provisional and may be subject to amendment. A learner's final results will be recorded on an OCR certificate.

The qualification title will be shown on the certificate as 'OCR Level 3 Advanced Subsidiary GCE in Sociology'.

4e. Post-results services

A number of post-results services are available:

- **Enquiries about results** – If you are not happy with the outcome of a learner's results, centres may submit an enquiry about results.
- **Missing and incomplete results** – This service should be used if an individual subject result for a learner is missing, or the learner has been omitted entirely from the results supplied.
- **Access to scripts** – Centres can request access to marked scripts.

4f. Malpractice

Any breach of the regulations for the conduct of examinations and coursework may constitute malpractice (which includes maladministration) and must be reported to OCR as soon as it is detected.

Detailed information on malpractice can be found in the JCQ *Suspected Malpractice in Examinations and Assessments: Policies and Procedures*.

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5 Appendices

5a. Grade descriptors

Details to be confirmed by Ofqual.

5b. Overlap with other qualifications

There is no significant overlap between the content of this specification and those for other AS level qualifications.

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